

Psalms 11

Refuge When Foundations Shake

In the Lord put I my trust: how say ye to my soul, Flee?

KJV · Standalone study handout

1 · THE WORD (KJV)

- 1 *In the LORD put I my trust: How say ye to my soul, Flee as a bird to your mountain?*
- 2 *For, lo, the wicked bend their bow, they make ready their arrow upon the string, that they may privily shoot at the upright in heart.*
- 3 *If the foundations be destroyed, what can the righteous do?*
- 4 *The LORD is in his holy temple, the LORD'S throne is in heaven: his eyes behold, his eyelids try, the children of men.*
- 5 *The LORD trieth the righteous: but the wicked and him that loveth violence his soul hateth.*
- 6 *Upon the wicked he shall rain snares, fire and brimstone, and an horrible tempest: this shall be the portion of their cup.*
- 7 *For the righteous LORD loveth righteousness; his countenance doth behold the upright.*

2 · CONTEXT

Psalm 11 is a psalm of David set in a moment of counseled retreat: friends urge flight because the wicked draw bows in secret and the very “foundations” of order seem destroyed. Henry reads it as a model of settled faith that refuses panic-driven advice, while the broader evangelical tradition notes the psalm’s hinge at verse 4—crisis on earth answered by the certainty of God’s throne in heaven. It sits among the “trust” psalms that ground personal courage in the character and government of God rather than in changing circumstances.

3 · VERSE-BY-VERSE COMMENTARY

The notes below cover the whole chapter in one place—read with the KJV text above.

Verse 1-3

Voices urge David to flee like a bird to the mountain, since the wicked secretly bend the bow to shoot at the upright in darkness and the foundations themselves seem destroyed. The implied question—what can the righteous do when the very order of things collapses—names a fear every generation faces when institutions or safety nets fail.

Verse 4-5

David answers not with a strategy but with a vision: “The Lord is in his holy temple, the Lord’s throne is in heaven.” His eyes behold and his eyelids try the children of men—nothing escapes the King who still reigns above the chaos. He tries both the righteous and the wicked, and His soul hates the one who loves violence.

Verse 6-7

Judgment imagery—snares, fire, brimstone, a horrible tempest—describes the wicked’s eventual portion, the natural harvest of chosen violence. The psalm closes on the opposite note: the righteous Lord loves righteousness, and the upright will behold His face—present favor now, unclouded fellowship in the end.

4 · MEANING & APPLICATION

Meaning.

Panic and flight are not the only options when foundations seem to crumble; the Lord’s unshaken heavenly throne and His moral government over both righteous and wicked give steady ground for present trust and future hope.

Application for life today.

When advisors, news, or your own instincts say “flee” from a hard situation, Psalm 11 offers a different first move: look up before you look for an exit. Let God’s ongoing scrutiny (“trieth the righteous”) prompt honest self-examination rather than only outward blame. And when violence or injustice seems to be winning, remember its “portion” is already appointed—your job is faithfulness, not private vengeance.

5 · REFLECT & RESPOND

Write your answers in the space below. There are no “right length” answers—honesty before God is the aim.

1. What “flee” counsel—fear, cynicism, isolation—are you tempted to follow when your circumstances feel unstable?

2. How does picturing God’s throne “in heaven” change how you interpret today’s instability?

3. Where might God be trying your heart right now, and how will you respond to what He finds?

Name: _____ Date: _____ Group / Church: _____

Sources: King James Version (public domain); Matthew Henry, *Commentary on the Whole Bible* (themes summarized); Expository themes consistent with MacArthur Study Bible tradition (paraphrased, not quoted). Scripture: King James Version (public domain).